Serious game and writing assignment – Mountain Climate Risks in bilateral negotiations

International boundaries often run along and across mountain ranges. Any risk scenarios unfolding within these mountain areas quickly call for countries to coordinate anticipatory action, response in disaster situations and even coordinated efforts in communicating those risks at the global stage. This becomes especially accentuated when those risks accumulate along essential trade routes, in areas where tourism is essential and where political stability is often difficult to ascertain and discontent among marginalized mountain communities can be high. For our course we are interested in the long southern border of China, that touches among other countries, Pakistan and Nepal. China has highways connecting to both of these countries, with plans to upgrade these links with railroad connections. The corridors are however also seriously affected by a number of mountain hazards and are home to many different ethnicities and mountain communities. Including the highest (China-Nepal) and second highest (China-Pakistan) mountain in the world, they are also important tourism regions. A general overview is shown in Figure 1.

On the 28th and 29th of May we will enact a *serious game*, where each of you will turn into one stakeholder from one of these three countries. You will be assigned a certain role in the country's delegation, which comes with hypothetical interests that you can develop based on your background research on the country and your understanding on what interests e.g. a politician or a representative from an indigenous community may want to convey. Your goal is to develop sustainable strategies to address mountain risks in your border regions. Very specifically, trade, tourism and as a result bilateral relations are under threat as the main connecting arteries between the countries are constantly threatened to be disrupted. What strategies can China develop with Pakistan on the one hand and Nepal on the other? What can they offer, what do they want in return? What geopolitical considerations may be at play. Consider the regional strategy called 'Belt and Road Initiative' (*yidai yilu*). How may Pakistan and Nepal try to exchange and strategize? Think also in other dimensions than trade, like education, migration and global conflict. Your ideal final goal should be bilateral (or even a multilateral one?) agreements to address mountain risks in the target region (and if you are brave as global leaders).

This serious game is a variation of a game played at the UN in Vienna in 2022 between actual representatives from mountain regions. The process is summarized here and you can watch a short video on the game here. These negotiations are also based on currently ongoing deliberations between these three countries, I have been involved in as an outside expert.

To come prepared for the game and your short writing assignment you should read up on some of the background literature provided for the country and any material you may find online. You will have two tasks:

1) Based on the material assigned to you as well as your own cursory research, write a short commentary, no longer than 1 page, that (a) briefly summarizes the content, (b) assesses to what degree the country is able to document its mountain related risks (or is maybe doing so already) and (c) what in your view seems crucially missing to do to come prepared to a negotiating table. You are free to use any material you can find beyond the links provided – they are just supposed to provide an entry point. In your essay, however, make sure to clearly refer on which reading material you base your analysis on. The commentary will be submitted as a 1 page document at the end of the course and makes up 40% of your grade.

2) Try to put yourself in the shoes of the person's profile you have been assigned (whether you may agree with that person's views and intentions or views, you can also choose to take up an especially contrarian or controversial character) to be prepared for the national negotiations, as well as the international discussions that will follow. Your aim will be first to shape the national standpoint based on your interests, and then to find an agreement with representatives of the other two countries. At both levels the negotiations can either lead to an absolute agreement, a disagreement or a rapprochement that simply leads into recommendations for future deliberations. Participations in these discussions make up 40% of your overall mark.

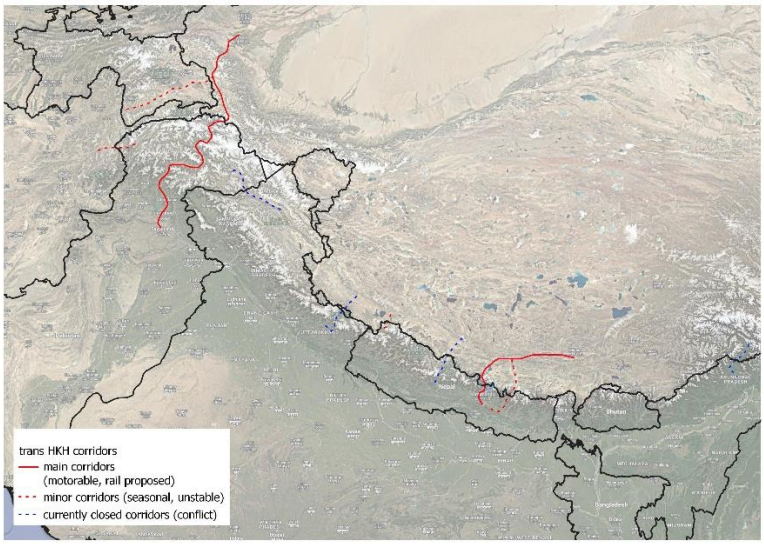


Figure 1: The two open trade corridors from China to Pakistan (Karakoram Highway, Kashgar to Islamabad, left) and China to Nepal (Kyirong Highway, Lhasa to Kathmandu, right).

Members of the civil society generally represent some part of the mountain population and come with experiences from mountains. They can have strong disagreements with representatives of their own country already. An example is the global indigenous data alliance (https://www.gida-global.org). Members of academia come with the background of having done their research, with data and local and global assessments. They work in national as well as global networks (like for example https://mountainresearchinitiative.org/). Members of ministries have an interest to represent their respective topic (e.g. agriculture, economy, environment) as well as their country, while being aware to have to commit to certain deals that may become binding at the global stage (e.g. certain quantitative commitments). Representatives of the international agency group work with international bodies (the UN, the World Bank etc.) with a mandate to work with government actors to increase resilience against risks, develop adaptation strategies and deliver monetary assistance through global funds. Business representatives are in general interested to benefit their company's balance sheet.

<u>Serious Game Schedule:</u>

28th of May 13:30 – 15:00: National deliberations.

All nations meet in separate breakout rooms to discuss the position of their country, the necessity to address risks (and which ones), their goals for the international deliberations (e.g. financial commitment by others, binding or non-binding agreements on certain issues, common strategies to address issues or invest in more research or infrastructure development or protection measures) and whether nationally they agree on a general direction. Keep in mind, you can

estimate a little bit from the country sheets and your general knowledge what the potential strategies of the respective other countries will be and strategize how you can take advantage of that.

29th May 09:00 – 10:30: Thematic negotiations.

The respective thematic groups will come together in side meetings to discuss a course of action across countries (i.e. all ministers meet, all representatives of businesses etc). Every representative will have a few minutes to pitch their main interests. You will then have time to discuss whether you can agree on a common strategy, whether the deliberations end in complete disagreement, or you find some common ground but need more time to investigate or invest. At the end of this 1.5 hours, you will need to choose one team member to then present a summary of your discussion in the Plenary Session.

29th May 10:30 – 12:00: Plenary Session.

For each of the groups one person will present the outcomes, either (a) presenting an agreement on commitments and a common strategy, (b) a breakdown of the dialogue and disagreement between all parties or some factions within the group or (c) a partial agreement that requires further initiatives, e.g. financing from other domains (or other countries), investment in research or investment in engagement with interests groups maybe not present during these discussions of just three countries. Across those groups you should then have a discussion of how those plans can be brought into agreement and discuss whether any kind of written agreement with a concrete plan for the coming years can be agreed upon or a strategy to bring this further to the global stage can be developed.

12:00 – 13:00: Break.

13:00 – 15:00: Wrap Up. Feedback and final lecture on real case scenarios

General notes:

reading: The publications you are assigned in your group are a recommendation. If you do find material you would rather investigate that also fits your profile please do so. The content may also not sit well with the interests you may want to represent in your *fictional* role. In your writing assignment you have the space to critically reflect on that as yourself, in the serious game you should try to use this information for your own interests benefits.

time: Time is very short for this exercise. This is because of the course time limitations, but also reflects a real life scenarios. Such international summits are generally never long enough to get everything said or done and its paramount you come well prepared and try to strike compromises.

outcomes: You may find it hard to come to satisfying conclusions. Welcome to the real world! As we will also discuss in the course, the outcomes from these summits so far as been rather sobering when it comes to actual hard agreements. So don't be too hard on yourself if you do not get to concrete conclusions but try to focus on formulating clear steps (or criticisms).

Country Profile China

Governance: Unitary state with one-party system

33 – 65 % covered in mountains

1.4 billion inhabitants

GDP per capita	14 800 USD
HDI	0.797

Main exports across the Himalaya: tools, textiles, technology, cars

Delegation:

Ministerial representation:	minister for finance or economics
Business representation:	representative from BYD
Business representation:	representative of CSCEC or CCCC
Academic representation:	professor in Geohazards at IMHE Chengdu

general hints:

China is interested to export both goods but also labour to neighbouring countries, due to their surplus workforce. The country is generally risk averse and is engaged with all other neighbouring countries as well, trying to balance geopolitical tensions.

literature:

ministry: https://www.tandfonline.com/doi/full/10.1111/j.1467-8306.2004.00412.x

business (cars): https://www.thedailystar.net/business/news/japanese-automakers-losing-market-share-southeast-asia-amid-increased-competition , https://kathmandupost.com/money/2025/11/12/ev-imports-drop-12-percent-as-floods-and-landslides-disrupt-northern-trade-routes

business (construction): https://link.springer.com/chapter/10.1007/978-3-319-72026-5_20

academia: https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S0169555X25004994

Country Profile Nepal

Governance: Federal democratic republic

80 % covered in mountains

29.6 million inhabitants

GDP per capita	1500 USD
HDI	0.622

Main exports across the Himalaya: tourism, climbing guides (to China and Pakistan)

Main imports across the Himalaya: cars, food, clothes, building material

Delegation:

Civil society representation:	representative of local communities in border regions (Tibetan)
Ministerial representation:	head of the Disaster Management Authority (NDRRMA)
Academic representation:	professor in ecology/forestry
Academic representation:	member of Climate Analytics/representative to COP meetings
International agency:	Asian Development Bank

general hints:

Nepal is dependent on both India and China for exports, while being impacted by hazards that travel across the border from China into the country. It also has a large young population that is looking for opportunities for work and studies abroad. It has good relations with both China and Pakistan, culturally being more similar to Pakistan. Mountain tourism plays a big role in the country.

literature:

civil society:

https://scholar.colorado.edu/concern/graduate_thesis_or_dissertations/pg15bf04z

https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/abs/10.1177/2399654420911410g

ministry: https://ndrrma.gov.np/en

academia: https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S0143622815002167

international agency: https://www.adb.org/projects/documents/reg-57059-001-tar

Country Profile Pakistan

Governance: Federal parliamentary republic

65 % covered in mountains

260 million inhabitants

GDP per capita 14 00 USD

HDI 0.544

Main imports across the Himalaya: tools, textiles, technology, food stuffs

Main exports across the Himalaya (Central Asia): wheat, rice

Delegation:

Civil society representation: representative of local communities in border regions (Ismaili, see Aga Khan Foundation, AKAH)

Ministerial representation: Coordinator to the Prime Minister on Climate Change

Business representation: lead of hydropower development projects

Academic representation: professor in glaciology/hydrology

International agency: UNDP (GLOF-II project)

general hints:

Pakistan depends on China for financial support and support in infrastructure development. Contrary to Nepal the country has a strong Industry, tourism is less developed but also growing rapidly, especially for the middle class travelling to the mountain regions.

literature:

civil society: https://the.akdn/en/how-we-work/our-agencies/aga-khan-agency-habitat

ministry: https://gcisc.org.pk/prime-minister-of-pakistan-minister-in-charge-ccec/

business: https://link.springer.com/chapter/10.1007/978-3-319-72026-5_20

academia: https://nhess.copernicus.org/articles/13/1551/2013/

International agency: https://www.greenclimate.fund/project/fp018#documents